

## CORE FORMULA

Notice the shift impulse -> support their thread -> invite one more detail -> share only if it adds value -> return to them. -> Short form: notice -> respond -> invite -> calibrate -> release. -> “That sounds rough — what part went wrong?” then actually listen before you relate. -> “I’ve been there too, but yours sounds like the bigger story. What happened?” -> “That’s a big one. What was the best bit?” — support the win before you match it.

## MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Before saying “That happened to me too”, say one support line first: “That sounds like a lot — what happened next?”

## BEST FOR

- Someone shares news, stress, an achievement, disappointment or story
- You feel a strong urge to say “me too”
- You want reciprocity without taking over
- A friend is venting and you want to help without redirecting
- Responding to good or bad news without competing
- Group conversations where quick hijacks are common

## PHRASE BANK

### Quick and digital · Short, text-length support

- "What happened next?"
- "How did that land?"
- "That makes sense."
- "Tell me the key bit."
- "What was that like?"
- "Go on — I'm listening."
- "That's a lot."
- "Oof, that's rough — what happened?"
- "Nice one. What made it work?"
- "Say more?"

### Warmth and acknowledgement · Social / support / validation

- "That sounds intense — what was that like?"
- "That is a big one. What happened next?"
- "I can see why that stuck with you."
- "Before I jump in with my version, tell me the best part."
- "That sounds like a lot to carry."
- "No wonder that stayed with you."
- "I'm really glad that worked out — what was the best of it?"
- "That sounds like it mattered to you."
- "Take your time. I want to hear it."

### Work and meetings · Professional / client / decision

- "That sounds like it took real effort. What was the key obstacle?"
- "That is useful context. What did you decide from there?"

- "Before I add my experience, what mattered most in your case?"
- "That's a real result. What made the difference?"
- "Sounds like a tough call — what tipped it?"
- "I've seen something similar, but I'd rather hear your read first."
- "That's helpful background. What did you weigh up?"

#### Invite one more detail · Draw the thread out

- "What part went wrong?"
- "What was the hardest bit?"
- "What made it work?"
- "What was the turning point?"
- "What mattered most to you in that?"
- "What happened after that?"
- "What are you making of it now?"
- "What's the part you're still turning over?"

#### Hand the floor back · Recovery / return the thread

- "Actually, your bit is the important one here."
- "Let me stay with your point for a second."
- "Before I jump in with mine, tell me the rest."
- "I'll tell my version later — what happened with yours?"
- "Sorry, that was me taking over. Go on."
- "I don't want to bulldoze your story. Keep going."
- "I meant to relate, not take over."

#### When it's tense or raw · Distress or high pressure

- "That sounds genuinely hard. I'm here — what do you need right now?"
- "Let's stay with what happened to you first."
- "I'm not going to make this about me. Go on."
- "That's a lot to hold. Take your time."
- "You don't have to rush it. What happened?"
- "I hear how much this got to you."
- "Whatever I've been through can wait — this is about you."

### WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

- Weak: Same thing happened to me. (Shifts straight to yourself and can feel like a hijack.)  
Better: That sounds familiar — what happened next? (Acknowledges the link but keeps their thread alive.)  
**Best: I've got a related story, but yours sounds like the important bit. What was the turning point? (Names the reciprocity while protecting their moment.)**
- Weak: Oh, I did that last year. (Turns their win into your anecdote.)  
Better: That's a great result — how did you pull it off? (Celebrates before relating.)  
**Best: That's brilliant. What was the best part for you? I've done something similar, but I want to hear yours first. (Support, invite, then reciprocity.)**
- Weak: You think that's bad, let me tell you about my week. (Competes with their stress.)  
Better: That sounds draining. What was the worst of it? (Stays on their thread.)  
**Best: That sounds genuinely hard. Talk me through it — I won't turn it into my own saga. (Support with a light, honest reassurance.)**

### DECISION TREE

#### If You feel a self-story rising

Pause and support their thread first.

*""That sounds like a lot — what happened next?""*

### **If They asked about your experience**

Share briefly, then return the floor to them.

*“I’ve had something like it, but tell me how yours ended.”*

### **If They are giving short answers**

Stop probing; offer a reciprocal contribution or a graceful exit.

*“No pressure to get into it — I just wanted to check in.”*

### **If Your story is bigger than theirs**

Hold it back unless it clearly helps them.

*“Yours is the one that matters here. What was the turning point?”*

### **If They have finished and turned to you**

Share your related bit, then hand the thread back.

*“That reminds me of something similar — but first, how are you feeling about it?”*

## **SCENARIOS**

### **A friend shares a stressful day**

Support the stress thread before mentioning your own day. — *“That sounds exhausting. What was the worst part?”*

### **A colleague shares a win**

Ask what made it work before offering your similar project. — *“That’s a great result — what made the difference?”*

### **Text or DM exchange**

Send one support line before any related anecdote. — *“Oof, that’s rough — what happened?”*

### **Group conversation after a pile-on**

Hand the floor back to the original speaker once others have jumped in. — *“Wait — I want to hear how yours actually ended.”*

### **Someone shares bad news**

Acknowledge and slow down before relating anything of your own. — *“I’m really sorry. How are you holding up?”*

### **You genuinely have a strong “me too”**

Support and invite first, then offer your version briefly and hand back. — *“I’ve been through something like that. But tell me yours first — what happened?”*

## **WHEN NOT TO USE**

- The other person directly asks about your experience
- The conversation has clearly moved into mutual exchange
- Your own disclosure is urgent or safety-relevant
- You are using support lines to stall or avoid saying what you actually mean
- Physical safety or an emergency needs a direct response first
- You have nothing genuine to relate and a support line would sound hollow

## **7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL**

### **Day 1 — Spot the impulse**

Through one ordinary day, silently tally each time you feel the urge to jump in with your own story. Change nothing else — just notice how often the shift impulse fires.

### **Day 2 — Name three moments**

Write three real situations from the past week where a shift response would have hijacked the moment. For each, note what a single support line could have been instead.

### **Day 3 — Build the ladder**

For each of the three, write a weak line, a better line and a best line — support first, then invite, then optional reciprocity that still hands the floor back.

### **Day 4 — Say it short**

Say each best line aloud twice, then cut it by about a third so it sounds like ordinary speech rather than a script. Bin any line that sounds clever or coached.

**Day 5 — Field test, low stakes**

In one easy conversation, use the minimum viable move once: one support line before any “me too”. Afterwards, record what the other person did in response.

**Day 6 — Invite one more detail**

In two conversations, add exactly one invite question after your support line, then genuinely wait — no relating anything of your own until they’ve fully answered.

**Day 7 — Reciprocity, then hand back**

Use the full move once: support, invite, share your related bit briefly, then return the floor with a question. Note where it felt natural and where it felt forced.

**AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST**

- Did I support their thread before reaching for my own story?
- Did I use plain language rather than a script?
- Did I keep their autonomy intact — no pressure, no steering?
- Did I stop after one move instead of overusing it?
- Did I use a recovery line if I jumped in too fast?
- Did the exchange feel easier afterwards, or more self-conscious?